up support in the socialist world. China was vital in this regard. On 14 October, just six days before China attacked India, Moscow conveyed to Beijing that it would 'stand together with China' in the event of an India–China war. Garver suggests in addition that the Soviets may even have indicated the dates of the impending missile crisis, namely, late October to mid-November when US congressional elections were due. This time frame coincided nicely with Beijing's eventual plans to go to war with India.[76]

India's mistakes

China was also helped by India's failure to sufficiently prepare for a large-scale attack. After the collapse of the 1960 Nehru–Zhou summit, Mao approved the setting up of forward posts in Ladakh.[77] Indian intelligence noted, however, that when the Chinese encountered Indian units, they would avoid challenging them: in September 1961, the Intelligence Bureau (IB) reported that 'when even a dozen of our men are present, the Chinese have kept away'.[78] This suggested that the Chinese were reluctant to escalate. The Indians concluded that part of the reason for Chinese restraint was geography. The Himalaya posed serious logistical challenges even for the PLA: if the Chinese advanced too far into Indian territory their supply lines would stretch longer and longer back into Tibet.[79] India therefore could push its forces ahead to check the Chinese and even encircle them by means of its Forward Policy.

What Nehru and his key advisers failed to understand was that China's aim was not to mount an invasion. It was to capture key areas near the border and then dig in. As Steve Hoffmann in his detailed reconstruction of Indian thinking notes: 'given his [Nehru's] personal lack of military experience or inclination, the prime minister was unable to imagine that a Chinese military move in NEFA or Ladakh could be something less than an invasion but more than another border incident. He did not speculate on the range of options open to Chinese ground forces, options that might preclude great-power intervention.'[80] The Forward Policy might have dealt with